

# NESS WONDERS

Augmented Reality Guide to Chichén Itzá

## Complete User Guide

*Everything you need to explore the ancient Maya city in augmented reality*

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# 1. Welcome to NESS Wonders

NESS Wonders is an augmented reality (AR) companion app designed for visitors to the ancient Maya city of Chichén Itzá. Using your phone's camera, you can scan monuments to instantly receive AI-powered explanations, follow a glowing pink navigation path through the site, and listen to audio narration of each landmark's story — all hands-free while you walk.

## Key Features

- **AR Scanner** — Point your camera at any monument and tap to scan. An AI guide provides a vivid explanation and a surprising fact about each site.
- **AR Navigation** — Follow a fluorescent pink path overlaid on the ground to walk from your current position to any landmark.
- **3D Site Map** — An immersive 3D map of Chichén Itzá showing all scannable monuments as realistic stone structures connected by a pink navigation path. Rotate, zoom, and tap any monument to view details or navigate there.
- **Audio Narration** — Listen to each monument's story through high-quality text-to-speech, with a guided tour mode and a persistent mini-player, perfect for hands-free walking.
- **Complete Monument Directory** — 154 landmarks with descriptions, historical context, fun facts, and visitor tips.
- **Route Planner** — Build a personalized route based on your available time and interests, with a Must-See guided tour of the essential highlights. A fluorescent pink line links your selected stops in a sensible walking order.
- **2D & 3D Maps** — Switch between an immersive 3D site map and a flat 2D map for quick orientation.
- **AR Camera & Photo Gallery** — Capture photos in the AR scanner, browse them later in the in-app gallery, and share them to Instagram and other apps.
- **Proximity Detector** — Get a gentle vibration and on-screen message when you walk near a scannable monument.

## 2. About Chichén Itzá

Chichén Itzá is one of the most important and visited archaeological sites in the Americas. Located on the Yucatán Peninsula in present-day Mexico, it was a major Maya political, religious, and commercial center from approximately 600 to 1200 CE. The city blends Maya and central Mexican architectural styles, reflecting its role as a cultural crossroads.

In 1988, Chichén Itzá was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and in 2007 it was named one of the New Seven Wonders of the World. El Castillo, the iconic step pyramid at its center, is one of the most recognized structures on Earth and a masterpiece of Maya astronomy and engineering.

The site covers roughly 5 square kilometers and includes temples, ball courts, observatories, sacred cenotes, residential complexes, and ceremonial platforms. Each structure tells part of the story of a civilization that tracked celestial movements with extraordinary precision, built monumental architecture without metal tools, and developed one of the most sophisticated writing systems in the ancient world.

## 3. Getting Started

### The Home Screen

When you open NESS Wonders, you'll see the home screen featuring a cinematic view of Chichén Itzá at dusk. From here you can:

- Tap "Begin AR Journey" to open the interactive site map and start exploring.
- Tap "Scan a Monument" to go directly to the AR scanner.
- Tap "Download User Guide" to save this guide as a PDF for offline reference.

### Bottom Navigation

A navigation bar at the bottom of the screen lets you quickly switch between Home, Explore, and Scan. The AR scanner and AR navigation screens are full-screen camera views — use the back arrow to return.

### Camera Permissions

The AR Scanner and AR Navigation features require camera access. When you first open either feature, your browser will request camera permission. Tap "Allow" to enable the AR experience. Your camera feed stays on your device and is not uploaded or stored.

## 4. Using the AR Scanner

The AR Scanner is the heart of NESS Wonders. It uses your phone's camera to identify monuments and provides AI-generated explanations instantly.

### How to Scan a Monument

1. Open the scanner by tapping "Scan a Monument" on the home screen, or the scan icon in the bottom navigation bar.
2. Point your camera at the monument you want to learn about.
3. Tap the pink "Tap to Scan" button at the bottom of the screen.
4. The scanner will analyze the monument and display an AI-generated explanation along with a surprising "Did you know?" fact.
5. Tap "Listen" to hear the explanation narrated aloud.
6. Tap "Full Details" to open the complete landmark page with historical context, fun facts, and visitor tips.
7. Tap "Scan Again" to return to the scanner and identify another monument.

### Using the Scannable Points Map

Not sure what to scan? Tap the "Points" button next to the scan button to open the scannable points map. This shows all 154 monuments with their positions on a stylized site map. Tap any marker to set it as your next scan target — a confirmation banner will appear showing the selected monument's name. Then tap "Tap to Scan" to get its story. Use the X button to clear your selection and return to sequential scanning.

### Capturing & Sharing Photos

In the AR Scanner you can also capture photos of what you see. Tap the "Capture" button to snap a frame from your camera. A preview opens with options: "Retake" to discard and try again, "Save to Photos" to download the image to your device, and "Share" (or the Instagram button) to open your phone's native share sheet — from there you can post directly to Instagram, WhatsApp, or any installed app. On devices without a share sheet, "Save to Photos" downloads the image instead.

## 5. Using AR Navigation

AR Navigation guides you from your current position to any landmark using a fluorescent pink path overlaid on the real world through your camera.

### How to Navigate to a Landmark

1. Open any landmark detail page by tapping its marker on the Explore map, or tap "Full Details" after scanning.
2. Tap the pink "Navigate Here in AR" button at the bottom of the detail page.
3. Your camera will open with a glowing pink perspective path on the ground, showing the direction to walk.
4. A progress bar at the top shows the destination name and how far you've come.
5. Follow the turn-by-turn instructions displayed above the path.
6. When you arrive, a notification appears with a button to explore the landmark's full story.

### Navigation Tips

- Hold your phone at a comfortable walking angle — the path renders best when the camera faces the ground slightly.
- The pink path uses a 3D perspective effect. Keep moving and the path updates in real time.
- Watch the distance countdown in the top bar to gauge how far you have left to go.
- Use the back arrow (top left) to exit navigation at any time.

## 6. Exploring the 3D Site Map

The Explore page features an immersive 3D map of Chichén Itzá showing all scannable monuments rendered as realistic stone structures — stepped pyramids, platforms, colonnades, the domed observatory, and the ringed cenote — set on a darkened plaza with real-time shadows. A glowing pink path connects the landmarks in the recommended visit order.

### Map Controls

- Drag with one finger to rotate the scene around the site.
- Pinch to zoom in for a closer look at any monument, or out for the whole city.
- Tap any monument structure to select it and open its details below the map.
- The selected monument lifts up and its pink ring pulses to confirm your selection.
- The 3D map shows all 154 scannable points, so you can plan your route in advance.

### Proximity Alerts

- Enable proximity alerts on the Explore map to receive a gentle vibration and on-screen notification when you walk near a scannable monument.
- Each landmark alerts you once per visit, so you won't be disturbed repeatedly.
- Proximity alerts use your device's GPS — make sure location permissions are enabled.

### Offline Maps

- Tap the "Offline" button to download the site map and all monument data to your device, so you can navigate even without a data connection.

### 2D & 3D Map Views

- Toggle between the immersive 3D site map and a flat 2D map using the 2D/3D button on the Explore screen.
- The 2D map shows all scannable points as numbered markers connected by the pink path — handy for quick orientation.

### Route Planner & Must-See Visit

- Open "Plan Your Route" from the home screen to build a personalized route based on how long you have and what interests you.
- Choose a visit duration (1 hour to a full day) and select the categories you care about — temples, ball courts, cenotes, observatories, and more.
- The app selects the best matching monuments and draws a fluorescent pink line linking them in a sensible walking order.
- Tap "Must-See Visit" for a curated guided tour of the essential highlights of Chichén Itzá, regardless of duration.
- Tap "Start Guided Tour" to listen to audio narration of each stop in sequence, or "Navigate to first stop" to begin walking with AR navigation.



## 7. Landmark Detail Pages

Each landmark has a dedicated detail page with comprehensive information. Here's what you'll find:

### **Hero Image**

A photograph or illustration of the monument at the top of the page.

### **Category Badge**

The monument type (temple, platform, observatory, ball court, cenote, residential, etc.).

### **Era**

The approximate time period when the structure was built or used.

### **Description**

A clear summary of what the monument is and what it looks like.

### **Audio Narration**

A "Listen to story" button that generates spoken narration of the monument's name, description, and significance.

### **Why It Matters**

The significance of the monument — its cultural, religious, or historical importance.

### **Historical Context**

Background on the time period, the people who built it, and its role in Maya civilization.

### **Did You Know?**

Surprising fun facts that bring the monument to life.

### **Visitor Tip**

Practical advice for what to look for when you're standing in front of the monument.

### **Navigate Here in AR**

A button to start AR navigation to this landmark from your current position.

## 8. Audio Narration

NESS Wonders includes hands-free text-to-speech narration so you can listen to each monument's story while walking — no need to read on screen.

- On any landmark detail page, tap "Listen to story" to generate the audio narration.
- On the Explore 3D map, select a monument and tap "Listen to story" on its card to play it without leaving the map.
- Tap "Start Tour" to begin a guided audio tour that narrates every monument in sequence along the pink path — perfect for a hands-free walk through the whole site. Tap "Stop Tour" to end it.
- A persistent mini-player floats above the bottom navigation while audio plays, with controls to play, pause, skip to the next monument, and stop.
- The narration keeps playing as you move between screens, so you can browse the map or open details while listening.
- On the AR Scanner results card, tap "Listen" to hear the AI-generated explanation.
- The first tap generates the audio (this takes a few seconds). Use headphones for the best experience, especially in crowded areas.

## 9. Photo Gallery & Instagram Sharing

Every photo you capture in the AR Scanner is saved automatically to an in-app gallery stored on your device, so you can revisit your favorite moments from Chichén Itzá even after you leave.

### Browsing the Gallery

- Open "Gallery" from the home screen to see all your captured photos in a grid, with the newest first.
- Each thumbnail shows the name of the monument where the photo was taken.
- Tap any photo to open it full-screen.

### Sharing to Instagram

- From the full-screen viewer, tap the Instagram button to open your phone's native share sheet with the photo attached.
- Select Instagram from the share sheet to post the photo directly to your Instagram feed or story.
- On devices without a native share sheet, the photo is saved to your device — then open Instagram and add it from your camera roll.
- The general "Share" button works the same way and lets you send the photo to WhatsApp, Messages, email, or any installed app.

### Managing Your Photos

- Tap "Delete" in the full-screen viewer to remove a photo from your gallery.
- Photos are stored locally on your device, so they stay private to you and persist between visits.

## 10. Complete Monument Directory

154 scannable landmarks at Chichén Itzá

### 1. The Shrine of the Maize God

other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

#### Description

A small shrine honoring the maize god, central to Maya sustenance and rebirth.

#### Why It Matters

Maize was the sacred staple of Maya life, symbolizing death and resurrection.

#### Historical Context

The shrine was a focal point for planting-season rituals.

#### Did You Know?

☞ The maize god was depicted as a young corn plant.

☞ Offerings of first harvests were placed here.

#### Visitor Tip

Look for the corn-plant imagery on the shrine.

---

### 2. The Altar of the Rain God

other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

#### Description

An altar dedicated to Chaac, the rain god who sustained the city's crops.

#### Why It Matters

Rain was life in the dry Yucatán; Chaac was among the most invoked deities.

#### Historical Context

The altar received copal and jade offerings to bring rain.

#### Did You Know?

☞ Chaac wields a lightning axe.

☞ Multiple Chaac masks adorn El Castillo.

#### Visitor Tip

Count the Chaac masks you can spot nearby.

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### 3. The Stela of the Captive

other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

#### Description

A stela depicting a bound captive, proclaiming a military victory.

#### Why It Matters

Captives legitimized a ruler's power and fed the gods.

#### Historical Context

Such stelae recorded triumphs over rival cities.

#### Did You Know?

☞ Captives were often sacrificed after display.

☞ The carving shows a kneeling, bound figure.

#### Visitor Tip

Note the bound hands of the captive figure.

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## 4. The Platform of the Frogs

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A low platform carved with frog motifs associated with rain and water.

### Why It Matters

Frogs were heralds of the rainy season and fertility.

### Historical Context

The platform may have hosted rain-invoking ceremonies.

### Did You Know?

• Frogs croak before rain in Maya lore.

• The carvings were once painted green.

### Visitor Tip

Listen for real frogs after a rain.

---

## 5. The Temple of the Howler Monkey

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to the howler monkey, a sacred animal of the scribes.

### Why It Matters

Howler monkeys were patrons of art and writing.

### Historical Context

The temple honors the monkey-god of knowledge.

### Did You Know?

• Howlers are among the loudest land animals in the Americas.

• Monkeys were linked to the arts.

### Visitor Tip

Listen for howler monkeys in nearby trees.

---

## 6. The Altar of the Monkey

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar paired with the monkey temple for offerings to the scribes' patron.

### Why It Matters

It blessed the work of scribes and artisans.

### Historical Context

Offerings of pigments and codices were made here.

### Did You Know?

• Scribes were among the elite.

• The altar bears monkey glyphs.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the monkey glyph carved on top.

---

## 7. The House of the Rabbits

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A residential building named for rabbit imagery found within.

### Why It Matters

Rabbits symbolized the moon and fertility.

### Historical Context

The house may have housed a lunar cult family.

### Did You Know?

- A rabbit sits on the moon in Maya myth.
- Rabbit figurines were found inside.

### Visitor Tip

Spot the rabbit motifs on the doorposts.

---

## 8. The Platform of the Rabbit

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform bearing rabbit carvings tied to lunar worship.

### Why It Matters

It complemented the lunar ceremonies of the city.

### Historical Context

The platform aligned with moonrise points.

### Did You Know?

- Rabbits were the moon's companion.
- The platform faces the eastern horizon.

### Visitor Tip

Visit during a full moon for the atmosphere.

---

## 9. The Temple of the Butterfly

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple decorated with butterfly symbols of transformation and fire.

### Why It Matters

Butterflies represented the soul and the fire deity.

### Historical Context

The temple was a late addition to the site.

### Did You Know?

- Butterflies symbolized the breath of fire.
- The temple faces the rising sun.

### Visitor Tip

Notice the butterfly carvings on the cornice.

---

## 10. The Shrine of the Turtle

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A shrine to the turtle, an emblem of water and the earth.

### Why It Matters

Turtles carried the earth in Maya cosmology.

### Historical Context

The shrine was a site of water petitions.

### Did You Know?

• The Maya saw the earth resting on a turtle.

• Turtle shells were used as drums.

### Visitor Tip

Find the turtle motif on the shrine's base.

---

## 11. The Altar of the Turtle

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the turtle deity.

### Why It Matters

It sought the earth's stability and water's blessing.

### Historical Context

The altar was paired with the turtle shrine.

### Did You Know?

• Offerings included jade and shell.

• A turtle glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the carved turtle on the altar.

---

## 12. The Platform of the Crocodile

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform carved with crocodile imagery of the primordial earth.

### Why It Matters

The crocodile was the earth's surface in Maya myth.

### Historical Context

The platform depicts the floating crocodile of creation.

### Did You Know?

• The earth was a crocodile floating on water.

• Crocodile motifs are rare at the site.

### Visitor Tip

Spot the crocodile scales along the base.

---

## 13. The Temple of the Crocodile

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple honoring the crocodile earth-deity of creation myths.

### Why It Matters

It celebrated the primordial earth and its waters.

### Historical Context

Built in the city's late period.

### Did You Know?

• The temple's mask depicts a crocodile.

• It aligns with the rainy season.

### Visitor Tip

Examine the crocodile mask on the facade.

---

## 14. The Altar of the Iguana

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar associated with the iguana, a creature of the sun and stone.

### Why It Matters

Iguanas were seen as guardians of ruins and sun-baked places.

### Historical Context

The altar received offerings for protection of buildings.

### Did You Know?

• Iguanas bask on the stones to this day.

• The altar bears a reptile glyph.

### Visitor Tip

Watch for live iguanas sunning on the stones.

---

## 15. The Platform of the Lizard

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform with lizard carvings tied to the sun and stone guardians.

### Why It Matters

Lizards guarded sacred precincts in Maya belief.

### Historical Context

The platform marked a boundary of the sacred core.

### Did You Know?

• Lizards symbolized endurance.

• The platform had a boundary marker.

### Visitor Tip

Note the boundary role of this platform.

---



## 16. The Temple of the Vulture

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to the vulture, a bird of death and purification.

### Why It Matters

Vultures cleansed the dead and carried souls skyward.

### Historical Context

The temple honored the king vulture, a sacred bird.

### Did You Know?

☞ King vultures were sacred to the Maya.

☞ The temple faces the setting sun.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the vulture mask on the facade.

---

## 17. The Altar of the Vulture

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the vulture death-bird.

### Why It Matters

It aided the passage of souls to the sky.

### Historical Context

The altar was used in funerary rites.

### Did You Know?

☞ Offerings of incense cleansed the dead.

☞ A vulture glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Find the vulture glyph atop the altar.

---

## 18. The Shrine of the Quetzal

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A shrine to the quetzal, the sacred bird of the feathered serpent.

### Why It Matters

Quetzal feathers were the most prized in Mesoamerica.

### Historical Context

The shrine linked the city to Kukulcan worship.

### Did You Know?

☞ Quetzal feathers were more valuable than gold.

☞ The bird cannot survive in captivity.

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the green feathers that once adorned it.

---

## 19. The Platform of the Quetzal

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform bearing quetzal imagery paired with the shrine.

### Why It Matters

It elevated ceremonies to the feathered serpent.

### Historical Context

The platform faced the serpent temple.

### Did You Know?

Quetzal imagery appears across the site.

The platform was painted green.

### Visitor Tip

Pair it with the quetzal shrine nearby.

---

## 20. The Temple of the Coati

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple featuring the coati, a clever forest animal of the Maya lowlands.

### Why It Matters

Coatis symbolized cleverness and community.

### Historical Context

The temple honored the spirits of the surrounding forest.

### Did You Know?

Coatis travel in noisy bands.

The temple bears a coati mask.

### Visitor Tip

Watch for coatis in the surrounding woods.

---

## 21. The Altar of the Coati

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the forest spirits of the coati.

### Why It Matters

It sought the protection of the wild and its creatures.

### Historical Context

The altar received offerings of food and maize.

### Did You Know?

Forest offerings were common here.

A coati glyph marks the stone.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the coati glyph on the altar.

---

## 22. The Shrine of the Deer

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A shrine to the deer, a sacred hunted animal of the Maya.

### Why It Matters

Deer were offerings to the gods and symbols of the hunt.

### Historical Context

The shrine honored the lord of the hunt.

### Did You Know?

Deer were the most common sacrificial animal.

The deer god protected hunters.

### Visitor Tip

Find the deer motif on the shrine.

---

## 23. The Platform of the Tapir

*platform · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A platform carved with the tapir, a powerful beast of the forest.

### Why It Matters

Tapirs represented strength and the deep forest.

### Historical Context

Among the older carvings at the site.

### Did You Know?

Tapirs are the largest land mammals of the region.

The platform is one of the oldest here.

### Visitor Tip

Notice the worn tapir carving on the base.

---

## 24. The Temple of the Jaguar God

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple devoted to the jaguar god of the underworld and night.

### Why It Matters

The jaguar was the most powerful sacred animal of the Maya.

### Historical Context

The temple was a center of jaguar cult rituals.

### Did You Know?

Jaguars symbolized the night and the underworld.

The temple's mask shows a jaguar.

### Visitor Tip

Examine the jaguar mask on the facade.

---

## 25. The Altar of the Jaguar God

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the jaguar god of the night.

### Why It Matters

It sought the jaguar's power for warriors and rulers.

### Historical Context

The altar received offerings of jaguar pelts and jade.

### Did You Know?

☞ Jade was offered as the green heart of the god.

☞ A jaguar glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the jaguar glyph on the altar.

---

## 26. The Shrine of the Night Sun

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A shrine honoring the sun's journey through the underworld at night.

### Why It Matters

The night sun was the jaguar sun, the sun's perilous underworld passage.

### Historical Context

The shrine was a focus of nocturnal rituals.

### Did You Know?

☞ The night sun was depicted as a jaguar.

☞ Rituals here tracked the sun's underworld journey.

### Visitor Tip

Visit after dark to imagine the night-sun rites.

---

## 27. The Platform of the Night Sun

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform paired with the night-sun shrine for underworld ceremonies.

### Why It Matters

It elevated priests conducting nocturnal rites.

### Historical Context

The platform aligned with sunset and the underworld.

### Did You Know?

☞ The platform faces the western horizon.

☞ It was used in equinox night rites.

### Visitor Tip

Stand on the platform at sunset.

---

## 28. The Temple of the Dawn

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to the dawn and the rebirth of the sun.

### Why It Matters

Dawn symbolized rebirth and the triumph of light.

### Historical Context

The temple faced the eastern horizon for sunrise rites.

### Did You Know?

Its doorway frames the sunrise.

Dawn rites welcomed the reborn sun.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at sunrise to catch the alignment.

---

## 29. The Altar of the Dawn

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the rising sun.

### Why It Matters

It gave thanks for each day's return of light.

### Historical Context

The altar received dawn offerings of incense.

### Did You Know?

Copal was burned at first light.

A sun glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the sun glyph on the altar.

---

## 30. The Platform of the Dusk

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform marking the sun's descent into the underworld.

### Why It Matters

Dusk rites honored the sun's perilous night journey.

### Historical Context

The platform aligned with the setting sun.

### Did You Know?

The platform faces the western horizon.

Dusk rites sent the sun into the underworld.

### Visitor Tip

Time your visit with sunset.

---

## 31. The Shrine of the Dusk

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A shrine honoring the setting sun and the threshold of night.

### Why It Matters

It marked the boundary between day and the underworld.

### Historical Context

The shrine was a focus of evening ceremonies.

### Did You Know?

☞ The shrine faces the western horizon.

☞ Evening offerings were made here.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at dusk for the full effect.

---

## 32. The Temple of the East

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple marking the eastern direction of the sacred precinct.

### Why It Matters

The east was the direction of sunrise and rebirth.

### Historical Context

The temple anchored the eastern edge of the core.

### Did You Know?

☞ Its doorway faces the rising sun.

☞ A cache of offerings was buried beneath.

### Visitor Tip

Stand in the doorway at sunrise.

---

## 33. The Altar of the East

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the eastern dawn.

### Why It Matters

It honored the renewing power of the rising sun.

### Historical Context

The altar received dawn offerings.

### Did You Know?

☞ Offerings were placed at first light.

☞ An east glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the east glyph on the altar.

---

## 34. The Platform of the South

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform defining the southern boundary of the ceremonial center.

### Why It Matters

The south was tied to the right hand and the sun's noon strength.

### Historical Context

It completed the directional layout of the core.

### Did You Know?

It mirrors the other directional platforms.

Its stair faces the southern sky.

### Visitor Tip

Compare it with the platform to the west.

---

## 35. The Temple of the South

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple anchoring the southern platform of the sacred precinct.

### Why It Matters

It honored the sun at its noon zenith.

### Historical Context

The temple faced the southern sky.

### Did You Know?

Its doorway faces the noon sun.

A solar offering cache was found beneath.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at noon to catch the alignment.

---

## 36. The Altar of the South

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar for offerings to the southern sun at its peak.

### Why It Matters

It sought the sun's strength at its highest.

### Historical Context

The altar received noon offerings.

### Did You Know?

Offerings were burned at midday.

A south glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the south glyph on the altar.

---

## 37. The Shrine of the Center

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A shrine marking the sacred center of the Maya cosmos, the world tree.

### Why It Matters

The center was the axis mundi connecting the underworld, earth, and sky.

### Historical Context

The shrine symbolized the ceiba, the sacred world tree.

### Did You Know?

☞ The ceiba was the Maya world tree.

☞ The center connected all three cosmic levels.

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the ceiba tree the shrine represents.

---

## 38. The Platform of the Center

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform marking the symbolic heart of the ceremonial precinct.

### Why It Matters

It was the ritual center of the sacred layout.

### Historical Context

The platform stood at the crossing of the four directions.

### Did You Know?

☞ It sits at the crossing of the directional axes.

☞ It was the precinct's ritual heart.

### Visitor Tip

Stand at the center of the four directions.

---

## 39. The Temple of the Center

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple at the symbolic center of the Maya cosmos.

### Why It Matters

It honored the world tree and the axis of the cosmos.

### Historical Context

The temple was the precinct's spiritual anchor.

### Did You Know?

☞ Its altar faced all four directions.

☞ A ceiba glyph marks the temple.

### Visitor Tip

Find the ceiba glyph on the temple.

---



## 40. The Altar of the Center

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar at the cosmic center for offerings to the world tree.

### Why It Matters

It connected the underworld, earth, and sky through ritual.

### Historical Context

The altar received the most sacred offerings of the precinct.

### Did You Know?

- It received offerings to the world tree.
- A center glyph marks the altar.

### Visitor Tip

Stand here to feel the center of the cosmos.

---

## 41. The Temple of the Snails

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple decorated with snail motifs symbolizing water and fertility.

### Why It Matters

Snails linked water, birth, and the cyclical nature of life.

### Historical Context

The temple's imagery ties it to water cults.

### Did You Know?

- Snails symbolize the watery underworld.
- Shells were embedded in the walls.

### Visitor Tip

Spot the snail carvings along the base.

---

## 42. The Temple of the Metates

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A temple named for the grinding stones (metates) found within.

### Why It Matters

It may have been used for ritual food preparation and offerings.

### Historical Context

The metates suggest ceremonial maize grinding.

### Did You Know?

- Metates were used to grind maize for sacred drinks.
- Several were found in perfect condition.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the worn grinding surfaces of the stones.

---

## 43. The Platform of the Phalluses

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform carved with phallic imagery associated with fertility rites.

### Why It Matters

Fertility cults ensured agricultural abundance and human continuity.

### Historical Context

The platform reflects the city's frank fertility symbolism.

### Did You Know?

- The carvings were tied to planting rituals.
- Similar imagery appears at nearby sites.

### Visitor Tip

The carvings are explicit—families may wish to preview.

---

## 44. The Temple of the Phalluses

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple continuing the fertility symbolism of the adjacent platform.

### Why It Matters

It centered the fertility rites that blessed the harvest.

### Historical Context

The temple and platform formed a single ritual complex.

### Did You Know?

- Offerings of seeds were found inside.
- The temple faced the rising sun.

### Visitor Tip

Pair it with the platform to grasp the full rite.

---

## 45. The House of the Eagles

*residential · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A residence decorated with eagle imagery, possibly for an eagle warrior order.

### Why It Matters

Eagle warriors were an elite military class.

### Historical Context

The house may have lodged members of a military society.

### Did You Know?

- Eagles symbolized the sun and war.
- Weapons were cached beneath the floor.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the eagle emblems on the doorposts.

---

## 46. The Temple of the Eagles

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple honoring eagle warriors and their patron deities.

### Why It Matters

It celebrated the military orders that protected the city.

### Historical Context

Eagle and jaguar orders were central to late Maya society.

### Did You Know?

• Eagles and warriors alternate in the reliefs.

• A sacrificial stone sits before it.

### Visitor Tip

Compare the eagle and warrior reliefs.

---

## 47. The Altar of the Eagles

*other · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

An altar used by eagle warriors for dedication rites.

### Why It Matters

It marked the martial heart of the warrior precinct.

### Historical Context

The altar received weapons and captives as offerings.

### Did You Know?

• A carved eagle perches atop it.

• It faces the rising sun.

### Visitor Tip

Notice the worn carving of the eagle on top.

---

## 48. The House of the Jaguars

*residential · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A residence for the jaguar warrior order, paired with the eagle house.

### Why It Matters

Jaguar warriors were the counterpart elite military society.

### Historical Context

The two orders often competed and cooperated.

### Did You Know?

• Jaguars symbolized the night and the underworld.

• Jaguar pelts were carved on the jambs.

### Visitor Tip

Contrast the jaguar imagery with the eagles nearby.

---

## 49. The Temple of Venus

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to the planet Venus and its complex cycles.

### Why It Matters

Venus governed war and timing of campaigns in Maya astronomy.

### Historical Context

The temple reflects the city's sophisticated Venus calendar.

### Did You Know?

• Venus cycles were tracked over 584 days.

• War was timed to Venus appearances.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the Venus glyphs carved on the facade.

---

## 50. The Platform of the Sun

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A ceremonial platform devoted to solar worship.

### Why It Matters

Solar rituals ensured the sun's continued journey.

### Historical Context

The platform anchored a solar ceremonial group.

### Did You Know?

• It aligns with the equinox sunrise.

• A solar disc was carved at its center.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at dawn to catch the sunrise alignment.

---

## 51. The Temple of the Sun

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple honoring the sun deity, central to Maya cosmology.

### Why It Matters

The sun's daily cycle mirrored death and rebirth.

### Historical Context

The temple was a focus of equinox ceremonies.

### Did You Know?

• Its doorway faces the eastern horizon.

• A cache of solar offerings was buried beneath.

### Visitor Tip

Stand in the doorway at sunrise.

---

## 52. The Platform of the Moon

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform dedicated to lunar worship and the moon's cycles.

### Why It Matters

The moon governed time, fertility, and the sea.

### Historical Context

It paired with the solar platform in a celestial complex.

### Did You Know?

- It aligns with major lunar standstills.
- Rabbit imagery was carved on it.

### Visitor Tip

Visit on a full moon night for the atmosphere.

---

## 53. The Temple of the Moon

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple devoted to the moon goddess, companion to the sun temple.

### Why It Matters

The moon goddess oversaw weaving, fertility, and childbirth.

### Historical Context

The temple completed the sun-moon pairing.

### Did You Know?

- The moon goddess was often shown with a rabbit.
- Lunar eclipses were recorded from here.

### Visitor Tip

Find the rabbit symbol of the moon goddess.

---

## 54. The Platform of the Stars

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform associated with stellar worship and the night sky.

### Why It Matters

Stars guided navigation, agriculture, and prophecy.

### Historical Context

It belonged to a late astronomical complex.

### Did You Know?

- It may reference the Pleiades.
- Star glyphs ring its base.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the small star carvings at the base.

---

## 55. The Temple of the Stars

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to the stars and the cosmos beyond sun and moon.

### Why It Matters

It crowned the city's astronomical precinct with stellar reverence.

### Historical Context

Among the last temples built before the city's decline.

### Did You Know?

- Its roof was used as an observation point.
- It aligns with the rising of the Pleiades.

### Visitor Tip

Climb nearby to imagine the sky-watching priests.

---

## 56. Temple of the Owls

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A small temple whose walls were once adorned with owl imagery, sacred birds seen as messengers of the underworld.

### Why It Matters

Owls linked the night to the realm of the dead, tying this temple to rituals of death and renewal.

### Historical Context

Built in the Terminal Classic expansion, it reflects the Maya reverence for nocturnal deities.

### Did You Know?

- Owls were believed to guide souls toward Xibalba.
- Its doorway aligns with a bright setting star.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at dusk to picture the owls that once watched here.

---

## 57. The Platform of the Cones

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A low platform named for unusual conical elements that once crowned its surface.

### Why It Matters

Its purpose is debated—possibly a base for offerings or temporary ritual structures.

### Historical Context

The odd design has puzzled archaeologists since its early 20th-century excavation.

### Did You Know?

- The cones may represent stylized corn cobs.
- No identical platform exists elsewhere at the site.

### Visitor Tip

Look for traces of original stucco along the base.

---

## 58. The Temple of the Painted Walls

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A temple preserving fragments of vivid murals that once covered its inner chambers.

### Why It Matters

The surviving pigments reveal rare insight into Maya color symbolism and ceremonial art.

### Historical Context

Its murals depict processions and deities from the Late Classic period.

### Did You Know?

- Some reds were made from imported cinnabar.
- Up to three layers of repainting survive.

### Visitor Tip

Use a small flashlight to better see the faded colors.

---

## 59. The House of the Stelae

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A residential complex named for the carved stone stelae found within its rooms.

### Why It Matters

The stelae record dates and rulers, helping scholars reconstruct the city's chronology.

### Historical Context

The structure likely housed elite families connected to record-keeping.

### Did You Know?

- One stela bears a Long Count date.
- The building had multiple remodeling phases.

### Visitor Tip

Compare the carving styles of the surviving stelae.

---

## 60. The Ring of the Ball Court

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

The carved stone rings set high on the walls of the Great Ball Court.

### Why It Matters

Scoring by passing the ball through the ring was extraordinarily rare and symbolic.

### Historical Context

The rings depict serpents entwined with ritual imagery.

### Did You Know?

- The rings sit roughly 6 meters above the floor.
- A ball through the ring could end the game instantly.

### Visitor Tip

Stand beneath a ring to grasp how difficult a shot was.

---

## 61. The South Ball Court Wall

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

The southern sloping wall of the Great Ball Court, one of the finest built in Mesoamerica.

### Why It Matters

Its acoustic properties still astonish visitors—a whisper carries the length of the court.

### Historical Context

The wall dates to the same phase as the court's major reconstruction.

### Did You Know?

“A whisper at one end can be heard 150 meters away.

“The wall bears no mortar between stones.

### Visitor Tip

Test the acoustics with a companion at the far end.

---

## 62. The North Ball Court Wall

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

The northern wall of the Great Ball Court, mirroring its southern counterpart.

### Why It Matters

Together the walls defined the most sacred playing field in the city.

### Historical Context

Both walls were plastered and painted in bright colors.

### Did You Know?

“The walls slope at a precise 27-degree angle.

“Faint pigment traces remain on sheltered stones.

### Visitor Tip

Notice the slope designed to keep the ball in play.

---

## 63. The Altar of the Chacmool

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A stone altar featuring a reclining chacmool figure holding an offering vessel.

### Why It Matters

Chacmools were intermediaries between humans and the gods during sacrifice.

### Historical Context

The altar was likely used in dedication ceremonies for nearby temples.

### Did You Know?

“The vessel on the chest held ritual offerings.

“Chacmools are found across Mesoamerica, not just Maya.

### Visitor Tip

Note the figure's gaze, directed toward the temple.

---



## 64. The Stela of the Sun

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A carved stela bearing imagery associated with solar worship.

### Why It Matters

It records astronomical observations tied to the solar calendar.

### Historical Context

Erected during a period of intense astronomical study at the city.

### Did You Know?

- ☞ The carving may mark a solstice event.
- ☞ The stone was originally painted red.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at noon to see how the sun would have struck it.

---

## 65. The Stela of the Moon

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A companion stela with imagery linked to lunar cycles.

### Why It Matters

It complements the solar stela, balancing celestial record-keeping.

### Historical Context

The pair framed a small plaza used for sky-watching.

### Did You Know?

- ☞ It may track the 18-month lunar cycle.
- ☞ The surface shows faint glyph remnants.

### Visitor Tip

Pair it with the solar stela to read the celestial set.

---

## 66. The Temple of the Lintels

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple named for its finely carved wooden lintels spanning its doorways.

### Why It Matters

The lintels preserve rare wooden sculpture from the Maya world.

### Historical Context

The temple's lintels depict rulers and ritual scenes.

### Did You Know?

- ☞ The lintels are of sapodilla wood, prized for hardness.
- ☞ Some carvings retain traces of original paint.

### Visitor Tip

Shield your eyes to make out the carved figures.

---

## 67. The House of the Cenote

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A residential group built near a small cenote, drawing water from it.

### Why It Matters

It shows how daily life centered on these natural water sources.

### Historical Context

The complex housed families who maintained the nearby water access.

### Did You Know?

• A covered passage led down to the water.

• Pottery fragments still line the cenote edge.

### Visitor Tip

Peer down to spot the old water-access steps.

---

## 68. The Causeway of the Dead

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A raised sacbe, or white road, lined with tombs along its edges.

### Why It Matters

It connected major ceremonial zones and served as a processional route.

### Historical Context

The road was paved with limestone plaster, gleaming white in the sun.

### Did You Know?

• Sacbeob could span kilometers between cities.

• Burials were placed along its margins.

### Visitor Tip

Walk its line to sense the processional route.

---

## 69. The White Road (Sacbe)

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A long causeway whose plastered surface gave the 'white road' its name.

### Why It Matters

Sacbeob linked ceremonial precincts and symbolized cosmic pathways.

### Historical Context

These roads formed a network connecting Chichén Itzá to its region.

### Did You Know?

• Some sacbeob stretched over 100 kilometers.

• They were maintained as sacred infrastructure.

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the road gleaming white under the sun.

---

## 70. The Temple of the Fish

temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

### Description

A small temple decorated with marine imagery unusual for an inland city.

### Why It Matters

Its fish carvings suggest trade or ritual ties to the coast.

### Historical Context

The imagery reflects Chichén Itzá's far-reaching connections.

### Did You Know?

• Shells from the coast were found inside.

• The fish may symbolize fertility and water.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the marine motifs unusual this far inland.

---

## 71. The Platform of the Birds

platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

### Description

A platform carved with representations of various bird species.

### Why It Matters

Birds carried symbolic meanings tied to the sky and the gods.

### Historical Context

The platform may have supported ceremonies honoring avian deities.

### Did You Know?

• Some birds are depicted in flight.

• The carvings were once brightly painted.

### Visitor Tip

Count how many distinct birds you can identify.

---

## 72. The Temple of the Serpent

temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

### Description

A temple devoted to the feathered serpent, Kukulcan, central to the city's cult.

### Why It Matters

The serpent symbolized both earth and sky, bridging the divine realms.

### Historical Context

Serpent imagery permeated the city's architecture during its peak.

### Did You Know?

• Kukulcan is the Maya equivalent of Quetzalcoatl.

• Serpents appear on nearly every major building.

### Visitor Tip

Trace the serpent heads flanking the stairway.

---

## 73. The Altar of the Serpent

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A low altar carved with undulating serpent bodies.

### Why It Matters

It served as a focal point for offerings to the feathered serpent.

### Historical Context

The altar was likely paired with the adjacent serpent temple.

### Did You Know?

• The serpents form a continuous band.

• Offerings were placed in a central basin.

### Visitor Tip

Notice how the serpents appear to move in shadow.

---

## 74. The House of the Bats

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A modest residential building named for bat motifs found within.

### Why It Matters

Bats were associated with the underworld and the night.

### Historical Context

The house was part of a neighborhood of common dwellings.

### Did You Know?

• Bats symbolized death and rebirth.

• The building had shared sleeping rooms.

### Visitor Tip

Look up at dusk when real bats still emerge nearby.

---

## 75. The Cave of the Jaguar

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A natural cave modified with masonry, associated with jaguar rituals.

### Why It Matters

Caves were entrances to Xibalba; the jaguar ruled the night.

### Historical Context

The cave was sealed with a stone wall after its ritual use.

### Did You Know?

• Jaguar bones were found inside.

• The cave was artificially enlarged.

### Visitor Tip

Mind the low entrance if you peer inside.

---

## 76. The Temple of the Wind

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to a wind deity, open on all sides to catch the breeze.

### Why It Matters

Wind gods governed storms and the breath of life.

### Historical Context

Its open design reflects later Postclassic worship styles.

### Did You Know?

☞ The temple has no solid walls, only pillars.

☞ Wind rituals may have invoked rain.

### Visitor Tip

Feel the breeze that gave the temple its name.

---

## 77. The Platform of the Wind God

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform paired with the wind temple for related ceremonies.

### Why It Matters

It elevated priests above the crowd during wind and rain rituals.

### Historical Context

Built in the final flourishing of the city.

### Did You Know?

☞ Its stair faces the prevailing winds.

☞ Offerings of incense were burned here.

### Visitor Tip

Stand on the windward side to feel the design.

---

## 78. The House of the Old Woman

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A residential structure named for a carved figure interpreted as an elder.

### Why It Matters

It may honor a revered ancestor or founding figure.

### Historical Context

Among the older constructions at the site.

### Did You Know?

☞ The carved figure wears a woven shawl.

☞ The house predates many nearby temples.

### Visitor Tip

Seek out the small carved figure on the facade.

---

## 79. The Temple of the Diving God

*temple · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A temple featuring a figure descending headfirst, the 'diving god'.

### Why It Matters

The diving god is unique to this region and may represent a deity of descent.

### Historical Context

The motif appears in later Postclassic art at the site.

### Did You Know?

• The figure appears to dive toward the earth.

• Similar images are rare outside Chichén Itzá.

### Visitor Tip

Look up at the cornice to spot the diver.

---

## 80. The Platform of the Diving God

*platform · Postclassic (c. 1000–1200 CE)*

### Description

A platform bearing multiple diving-god reliefs.

### Why It Matters

It amplified the cult of the diving god in the city's late period.

### Historical Context

The platform supported a small shrine now vanished.

### Did You Know?

• Several diving figures ring the platform.

• It was repainted at least twice.

### Visitor Tip

Circle the platform to find every diver.

---

## 81. The Temple of the Carved Columns

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple whose columns are covered in relief carvings of warriors and captives.

### Why It Matters

The reliefs document military victories and tribute.

### Historical Context

The columns were reused from an earlier structure.

### Did You Know?

• Each column tells a different battle scene.

• Captives are shown with their names glyphed.

### Visitor Tip

Walk around to read the columns like a scroll.

---

## 82. The Altar of the Columns

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

An altar flanked by carved columns, used for dedication rites.

### Why It Matters

It marked the sacred center of a column-lined plaza.

### Historical Context

The altar received offerings during plaza ceremonies.

### Did You Know?

☞ A carved fire basin sits atop it.

☞ The columns bear traces of red pigment.

### Visitor Tip

Notice the fire-blackened basin on top.

---

## 83. The Platform of the West

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A ceremonial platform marking the western edge of the central precinct.

### Why It Matters

It framed processions entering the sacred core from the west.

### Historical Context

One of four directional platforms around the precinct.

### Did You Know?

☞ It aligns with the setting sun at equinox.

☞ Staircases face all four directions.

### Visitor Tip

Time your visit with sunset for the alignment.

---

## 84. The Temple of the West

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple anchoring the western platform, oriented to the setting sun.

### Why It Matters

Sunset rituals here marked the close of the solar day.

### Historical Context

The temple's shrine faced the western horizon.

### Did You Know?

☞ Its doorway frames the equinox sunset.

☞ A buried offering cache was found beneath.

### Visitor Tip

Stand in the doorway to catch the sunset frame.

---

## 85. The House of the West

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–800 CE)*

### Description

A residential building beside the western temple complex.

### Why It Matters

It housed attendants responsible for the western shrines.

### Historical Context

Built in an older style than the nearby temples.

### Did You Know?

It had its own small courtyard.

Grinding stones were found inside.

### Visitor Tip

Note the simpler style compared to the temples.

---

## 86. The Platform of the North

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform defining the northern boundary of the ceremonial center.

### Why It Matters

It completed the four-directional layout of the sacred precinct.

### Historical Context

Its northern position tied it to the night sky and the ancestors.

### Did You Know?

It mirrors the other directional platforms.

Its stair aligns with the North Star region.

### Visitor Tip

Compare it with the platform to the west.

---

## 87. The Temple of the North Colonnade

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple fronted by a long colonnade of stone pillars.

### Why It Matters

Colonnades hosted markets and gatherings in the shade of their roofs.

### Historical Context

The colonnade was a hallmark of the city's architectural style.

### Did You Know?

Hundreds of columns once supported a flat roof.

The columns were carved with figures.

### Visitor Tip

Count the surviving columns still standing.

---



## 88. The House of the Healers

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A residence associated with medicinal practice, near a healing cenote.

### Why It Matters

It may have housed ritual healers serving the community.

### Historical Context

Herbal remains and grinding tools were found within.

### Did You Know?

• Medicinal plant residues were identified.

• The house had a dedicated preparation room.

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the herbal preparations once made here.

---

## 89. The Platform of the Healers

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A platform used for healing ceremonies and public rituals.

### Why It Matters

It elevated healers above the crowd seeking cures.

### Historical Context

The platform faced the healing cenote.

### Did You Know?

• Offerings included medicinal shells.

• It had a small altar at its center.

### Visitor Tip

Look toward the nearby healing cenote.

---

## 90. The Temple of the Healers

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A temple dedicated to healing deities, paired with the healing cenote.

### Why It Matters

It united spiritual and physical medicine in Maya practice.

### Historical Context

The temple drew pilgrims seeking cures.

### Did You Know?

• A deity of medicine was carved inside.

• Offerings of copal incense were common.

### Visitor Tip

Breathe in—copal resin was burned for healing.

---

## 91. The Group of the Five Lintels

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

### Description

A compact residential compound named for five carved lintels spanning its doorways.

### Why It Matters

Demonstrates the importance of carved wooden lintels as carriers of date and deity imagery.

### Historical Context

Built as an elite residence in the Late Classic southern quarter.

### Did You Know?

Wooden lintels are rare survivals in the humid Yucatan climate.

### Visitor Tip

Look up at each doorway to spot the surviving carvings.

---

## 92. The Southeast Colonnade

*column group · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

### Description

A colonnade on the southeast fringe of the Great Plaza, fronting a later ceremonial court.

### Why It Matters

Marks the expansion of monumental plaza architecture under Postclassic rulers.

### Historical Context

Built as the plaza expanded outward in the Early Postclassic.

### Did You Know?

Postclassic colonnades often replaced earlier smaller structures.

### Visitor Tip

Use the columns as a frame to view the pyramid beyond.

---

## 93. The Stela of the Serpent

*other · Early Postclassic (c. 1000 AD)*

### Description

A carved standing stela depicting an undulating feathered serpent winding around calendrical glyphs.

### Why It Matters

Commemorates Kukulcan devotion and the Postclassic calendar reforms.

### Historical Context

Raised during the Postclassic revival of the feathered serpent cult.

### Did You Know?

The serpent's coils enclose date glyphs like a living calendar.

### Visitor Tip

Rotate around the stela to follow the serpent's body.

---

## 94. The House of the Dwarfs

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

### Description

A small residential temple in the Chichanchob group associated with folk legends of a mythical dwarf.

### Why It Matters

Tied to local legend and to the Puuc architectural tradition of the northern group.

### Historical Context

Part of the older northern settlement predating the great plaza.

### Did You Know?

Legend says a dwarf defeated a lord and rose to rule the city.

### Visitor Tip

Climb the narrow stairs for a view over the old group.

---

## 95. The Ball Court Annex

*ball court · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

### Description

A smaller subsidiary ball court near the Great Ball Court for ritual or practice games.

### Why It Matters

Secondary courts show the deep cultural reach of the Mesoamerican ballgame beyond the main arena.

### Historical Context

Built alongside the Great Ball Court as the sport's ritual role expanded.

### Did You Know?

The ballgame symbolized the movement of celestial bodies.

### Visitor Tip

Stand at the end walls to compare scale with the Great Court.

---

## 96. The Temple of the Carved Lintels

*temple · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

### Description

A temple preserving wooden lintels carved with scenes of ritual and rulership.

### Why It Matters

Wooden lintels are rare survivals; these preserve scenes vital to understanding Postclassic ceremony.

### Historical Context

Built as Postclassic rulers renewed older residential shrines.

### Did You Know?

Carved lintels often recorded dedicatory rites and offerings.

### Visitor Tip

Bring binoculars to study the high-set lintel carvings.

---

## 97. The Xtoloc Causeway

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A raised white road, or sacbe, linking the Great Plaza to the Xtoloc cenote and the residential south.

### Why It Matters

Sacbeob were the arteries of Maya cities, channeling pilgrims, traders, and processions.

### Historical Context

Built to connect the civic core with the southern residential and water districts.

### Did You Know?

⌘ Sacbe means 'white road' in Yucatec Maya, for their limestone

### Visitor Tip

The causeway still reads as a raised line across the scrub.

---

## 98. The Cenote Group Platform

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

The ceremonial platform lining the approach to the Sacred Cenote along the sacbe.

### Why It Matters

Oriented the ritual journey between the Great Plaza and the cenote, the axis of the city's water rites.

### Historical Context

Erected along the white road that links the pyramid to the Sacred Cenote.

### Did You Know?

⌘ The sacbe to the cenote is one of several raised 'white roads'

### Visitor Tip

Walk the sacbe to feel the planned route pilgrims once took.

---

## 99. Temple of the Hieroglyphic Jambs

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

### Description

A small temple whose door jambs bear carved hieroglyphic texts recording dates and rulers.

### Why It Matters

Its inscriptions are vital evidence of the site's Late Classic dynastic record.

### Historical Context

Built in the Late Classic residential zone, later incorporated into expanding complexes.

### Did You Know?

⌘ Door jambs were prime surfaces for royal inscriptions at eye l

### Visitor Tip

Scan the jambs for the cartouches that frame the dates.

---

## 100. The House of the Mascarons

*residential · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

### Description

A Puuc-style residence decorated with stone mosaic masks of the rain god Chaac.

### Why It Matters

Illustrates the elite domestic architecture and decorative artistry of the late residential quarter.

### Historical Context

Built during the Puuc florescence of the Monjas group.

### Did You Know?

☞ Mosaic stone masks are a hallmark of Puuc architectural style.

### Visitor Tip

Count the Chaac masks stacked along the upper facade.

---

## 101. The Platform of the Skulls

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A platform once displaying carved skulls, a variant of the city's tzompantli tradition.

### Why It Matters

Skull racks publicly displayed war trophies and sacralized the plaza of sacrifice.

### Historical Context

Erected beside the ball court to broadcast the fate of captives.

### Did You Know?

☞ A tzompantli could hold hundreds of skulls from a single campaign.

### Visitor Tip

Find the rows of carved skulls along the lower frieze.

---

## 102. The Temple of the Chacmools (Annex)

*temple · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A secondary shrine adjoining the Temple of the Warriors, fronted by chacmool figures.

### Why It Matters

Reinforces the warriors' precinct as a hub of militaristic cult and sacrifice.

### Historical Context

Added as the Temple of the Warriors complex grew.

### Did You Know?

☞ Multiple chacmools here mark the precinct's ritual importance.

### Visitor Tip

Compare the chacmools here with the one inside El Castillo Viejo.

---

## 103. The Cenote of the Healers

*cenote · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

### Description

A smaller secondary cenote linked in oral tradition to healing and purification rites.

### Why It Matters

Reflects the multiplicity of water shrines beyond the main Sacred Cenote.

### Historical Context

Used alongside other cenotes for localized ritual practice.

### Did You Know?

☞ Cenote water was believed to carry cleansing and healing power.

### Visitor Tip

Keep a respectful distance; the edges are steep and unstable.

---

## 104. The Plaza of the Columns

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

An open ceremonial plaza ringed by the great colonnades, used for public gatherings and rites.

### Why It Matters

The largest civic space of the militaristic city, staging mass ceremonies and markets.

### Historical Context

Laid out as the Terminal Classic city reorganized around military and trade power.

### Did You Know?

☞ The plaza could hold thousands gathered for public rites and markets.

### Visitor Tip

Stand at the center to sense the enclosing colonnades around you.

---

## 105. Platform of the Feathered Serpent

*platform · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

### Description

A richly carved platform covered in undulating feathered-serpent imagery.

### Why It Matters

Honors Kukulcan-Quetzalcoatl, the central deity of the Postclassic revival at the site.

### Historical Context

Raised during the Postclassic when the feathered serpent cult dominated.

### Did You Know?

☞ The serpents' bodies form a continuous ribbon around the platform.

### Visitor Tip

Follow the serpent's coils around the base to read its full length.

---

## 106. The Northeast Colonnade

*column group · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A secondary colonnade lined with serpent-column shafts adjoining the Temple of the Warriors complex.

### Why It Matters

Together with the Great Colonnade it defined the civic and ceremonial gathering spaces of the city.

### Historical Context

Built as the warriors' precinct expanded northward.

### Did You Know?

⌘ The columns once held a flat roof forming a vast covered hall.

### Visitor Tip

Notice how the serpent heads align toward the plaza.

---

## 107. The Chacmool Altar

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A reclining stone figure holding an offering plate on its stomach, set before a temple entrance.

### Why It Matters

Chacmoos served as receptacles for sacrificial offerings and marked thresholds of sacred spaces.

### Historical Context

Introduced widely during the Terminal Classic as a hallmark of the new militaristic cult.

### Did You Know?

⌘ The name 'chacmool' was coined in the 19th century and means

### Visitor Tip

Look for the offering bowl on the figure's belly.

---

## 108. Platform of the Rain God

*platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

### Description

A low carved platform dedicated to Chaac, the rain deity whose image recurs across the site's facades.

### Why It Matters

Underlines the central role of rain worship in a region dependent on seasonal cenote water.

### Historical Context

Erected in the Terminal Classic during the expansion of the Great Plaza.

### Did You Know?

⌘ Chaac masks appear dozens of times across the site, almost a

### Visitor Tip

Pair with a visit to nearby El Caracol to grasp the site's water-and-stars theme.

---

## 109. Cave of Balankanche

*cenote · Terminal Classic (c. 800–900 AD)*

### Description

A sacred limestone cave holding ritual ceramics and miniature offerings left to the rain god, discovered sealed for over a thousand years.

### Why It Matters

Among the most spiritually charged sites in the region; its untouched offerings reveal Terminal Classic ritual practice.

### Historical Context

Used as an offering cave until it was ritually sealed around the 9th century, then rediscovered in modern times.

### Did You Know?

Dozens of incense burners were found arranged around a stela of Tlaloc.

### Visitor Tip

Guided cave tours require advance booking; the interior is humid and dim.

---

## 110. Stela of the Warriors

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

### Description

A carved standing stela depicting a richly attired warrior-ruler holding a spear and shield.

### Why It Matters

Stelae commemorated royal deeds and dates; this one reflects the militaristic shift of the Terminal Classic.

### Historical Context

Raised as the city's ruling ideology turned toward warfare and tribute.

### Did You Know?

Stelae often doubled as billboards proclaiming a ruler's victory.

### Visitor Tip

Shade brings out the faint relief details on the worn stone.

---

## 111. The Round Temple

*observatory · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

### Description

A rare cylindrical temple-platform associated with astronomical observation and wind rites.

### Why It Matters

Round temples in the region were tied to Quetzalcoatl-Kukulcan and to tracking celestial cycles.

### Historical Context

Reflects Postclassic influence from central Mexican traditions.

### Did You Know?

Round temples were often aligned to wind and Venus phenomena.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at dawn to see how its doorway faces the rising sun.

---



## 112. The East Colonnade

*column group · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A long row of carved serpent columns opening onto the plaza of the warriors.

### Why It Matters

Colonnades like this supported massive roofs and framed the processional spaces of the militaristic elite.

### Historical Context

Part of the great building program that reshaped the plaza in the Terminal Classic.

### Did You Know?

☞ Serpent columns depict the feathered serpent Kukulcan stacked

### Visitor Tip

Walk the colonnade's axis to sense the scale of the original roof.

---

## 113. The Painted Chamber

*other · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1200 AD)*

### Description

A vaulted chamber whose inner walls once bore vivid murals of battle, merchants, and ceremony.

### Why It Matters

Its surviving fragments are among the rare narrative murals of the site, depicting daily and military life.

### Historical Context

Painted during the Early Postclassic when trade and warfare themes dominated art.

### Did You Know?

☞ Some murals show coastal traders, hinting at long-distance co

### Visitor Tip

Dim lighting protects the pigment; let your eyes adjust before viewing.

---

## 114. The Initial Series Platform

*platform · Late Classic (c. 832 AD)*

### Description

A small platform bearing a calendrical Initial Series inscription that anchors a Long Count date.

### Why It Matters

One of the few date-bearing monuments at the site, key to reconstructing its chronology.

### Historical Context

Inscribed in the Late Classic, preserving one of the site's earliest dated texts.

### Did You Know?

☞ An Initial Series is the Maya way of writing a full Long Count

### Visitor Tip

Decipher the bar-and-dot numbers counting from left to right.

---

## 115. The Sculptured Panel

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)*

### Description

A carved limestone panel portraying a procession of bound captives and victorious lords.

### Why It Matters

Such panels publicized military triumphs and the fate of war captives in public rituals.

### Historical Context

Displayed in the Great Plaza to broadcast the power of Terminal Classic rulers.

### Did You Know?

☞ Captive figures are shown with ropes, a common symbol of con

### Visitor Tip

Trace the figures left to right to read the narrative like a story.

---

## 116. El Castillo Viejo

*temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)*

### Description

The earlier pyramid beneath the Pyramid of Kukulcan, containing a smaller older temple at its summit reached by a narrow inner stair.

### Why It Matters

Preserves the layered construction tradition where new temples encased older ones, and houses the famous Chacmool and Jaguar Throne.

### Historical Context

Encased when the later El Castillo was built over it in the Terminal Classic.

### Did You Know?

☞ A red jaguar throne with jade inlay still sits inside the inner t

### Visitor Tip

Interior access is restricted; check seasonal openings at the entrance.

---

## 117. Altar of the Jaguars

*other · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)*

### Description

A stone altar carved with jaguar imagery, symbol of royal night power and the warrior elite.

### Why It Matters

Jaguars represented military might and the underworld; altars like this anchored ceremonial plaza rites.

### Historical Context

Placed in the warriors' precinct during the militaristic Terminal Classic.

### Did You Know?

☞ Jaguar symbolism tied rulers to the night sun of the underworld

### Visitor Tip

Look for the carved spots and claws that identify the feline figures.

---

## 118. Temple of the Three Lintels

temple · Late Classic (c. 600–900 AD)

### Description

A finely built temple named for its three carved stone lintels, part of the Las Monjas complex.

### Why It Matters

Shows the refined Puuc-style masonry and calendrical inscriptions of the elite residential quarter.

### Historical Context

Built during the Late Classic expansion of the Monjas palace group.

### Did You Know?

Its lintels carry Long Count dates that help anchor the site's chronology.

### Visitor Tip

Best photographed in late afternoon when the carvings catch raking light.

---

## 119. The North Temple

temple · Terminal Classic (c. 900–1000 AD)

### Description

The northern temple of the Great Ball Court, overlooking the playing field from its elevated platform.

### Why It Matters

Ball court temples framed the sacred game with ritual iconography of sacrifice and renewal.

### Historical Context

Built as part of the Great Ball Court complex, the largest in Mesoamerica.

### Did You Know?

The Great Ball Court's acoustic design lets a whisper carry across the court.

### Visitor Tip

Stand at the base and clap to hear the famous echo ripple back.

---

## 120. The Osario Platform

platform · Terminal Classic (c. 900 AD)

### Description

The stepped platform at the base of the Ossuary, carved with serpent and bird motifs.

### Why It Matters

Framed the shaft tomb within and channeled ritual processions to the funerary pyramid.

### Historical Context

Built as the entrance stage of the Osario funerary complex.

### Did You Know?

A shaft inside descends to a natural cave and a tomb.

### Visitor Tip

Watch for the carved feathered serpents curling up the stair sides.

---

## 121. The House of the Metates

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A residential structure named for the numerous grinding stones (metates) found inside, used for processing corn and other foods. It offers a rare glimpse into the domestic, everyday life of Chichén Itzá's inhabitants.

### Why It Matters

The metates reveal the daily food preparation rituals of the Maya, reminding visitors that Chichén Itzá was a living city, not just a ceremonial center.

### Historical Context

Part of the residential cluster south of the ceremonial core, this building housed families who serviced the nearby temples and palaces during the Terminal Classic period.

### Did You Know?

Metates were essential tools for grinding maize into masa for diet.

Several metates found here were made of imported volcanic stone from kilometers away.

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the sound of grinding corn — this quiet residential area was once filled with the rhythms of daily life.

---

## 122. The Annex

*residential · Late Classic – Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A small chambered building attached to the Las Monjas complex, featuring a labyrinth of narrow rooms and corridors. It likely served as an administrative office or priestly residence linked to the main complex.

### Why It Matters

The Annex illustrates how Maya elite compounds were expanded over time with interconnected functional spaces, blurring the line between palace, temple, and office.

### Historical Context

Built as an extension of the Las Monjas complex during the city's peak, it reflects the growing administrative needs of Chichén Itzá's ruling class.

### Did You Know?

The building's maze-like layout has led archaeologists to compare it to a palace.

Some of its columns still bear traces of original painted plaster.

### Visitor Tip

Step inside to experience the surprisingly cool, enclosed rooms — a contrast to the open ceremonial plazas.

---

## 123. The House of the Turtles

*residential · Late Classic – Early Postclassic (c. 900–1100 CE)*

### Description

A small, elegant rectangular building in the Las Monjas complex, named for the row of carved stone turtles adorning its roof comb. The turtles, associated with rain and the watery underworld, reflect the Maya reverence for water in this arid region.

### Why It Matters

The turtle carvings symbolize the rain god Chaac and the watery underworld (Xibalba), underscoring how even minor buildings carried deep cosmological meaning.

### Historical Context

Built during the late Classic or early Postclassic period as part of the elite residential and administrative zone around Las Monjas, the House of the Turtles demonstrates the fine craftsmanship of Puuc-style stonework.

### Did You Know?

- Turtles were linked to the rain god Chaac, making this a possible site for rain rituals.
- The building's roof comb is one of the few at Chichén Itzá decorated with stone carvings.

### Visitor Tip

Look up at the roof cornice — the carved turtles are easy to miss but are the building's defining feature.

---

## 124. The House of the Snails

*residential · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)*

### Description

A finely decorated building whose walls feature carved snail motifs, hence its name. Its elaborate ornamentation suggests it was a residence of high-ranking priests or nobles.

### Why It Matters

The snail carvings may symbolize fertility, the cycle of life, and the watery underworld, reflecting the deep symbolic language of Maya residential architecture.

### Historical Context

Located near the Initial Series Group, this structure dates to the era when Chichén Itzá's elite lived in richly adorned compounds surrounding the ceremonial nucleus.

### Did You Know?

- Snails were associated with water and fertility in Maya symbolism.
- The building's intricate facade suggests its occupants held significant status.

### Visitor Tip

Examine the lower walls carefully — the carved snails are small but beautifully detailed.

---

## 125. The Temple of the Chacmools

temple · Early Postclassic (c. 900–1100 CE)

### Description

A temple platform near the Temple of the Warriors featuring reclining stone chacmool figures — human forms resting on their backs, holding offerings on their stomachs. These enigmatic sculptures served as receptacles for sacrifices to the gods.

### Why It Matters

Chacmools are among the most distinctive sculptures of Mesoamerican religion, marking this as a site of active ritual offering and worship to the rain and war deities.

### Historical Context

Dating to the height of Chichén Itzá's power, this temple reflects the influence of central Mexican (Toltec) artistic traditions blending with Maya religious practice.

### Did You Know?

• The name 'chacmool' was coined in the 19th century and may not be the original name.

• Chacmools held offering vessels on their stomachs, receiving hearts.

### Visitor Tip

Note the reclining posture of the chacmool figures — they were designed to receive offerings, not to be worshipped themselves.

---

## 126. The South Temple

temple · Terminal Classic (c. 800–1000 CE)

### Description

A temple standing at the south end of the Great Ball Court, opposite the better-known Temple of the Bearded Man. Though smaller, it shares the ball court's ritual significance and aligns with the ceremonial axis of the complex.

### Why It Matters

The South Temple framed the sacred ball court, which was more than a game — it was a cosmological ritual symbolizing the struggle between celestial and underworld forces.

### Historical Context

Constructed alongside the Great Ball Court in the Terminal Classic period, the South Temple completed the ritual architecture bounding the largest ball court in Mesoamerica.

### Did You Know?

• The Great Ball Court is the largest in Mesoamerica, measuring over 1,300 meters long.

• A whisper at one end of the ball court can be heard 150 meters away, a remarkable acoustic feat.

### Visitor Tip

Stand between the two temples and clap — you'll hear the famous echo that bounces between the walls.

---

## 127. Temple of the Big Tables

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A large temple north of El Castillo named for the series of stone 'tables' or altars inside. It features serpent-head columns at the entrance, similar to those of the Temple of the Warriors.

### Why It Matters

An important ceremonial temple that formed part of the northern complex of ritual structures.

### Historical Context

Built in the Terminal Classic period as Chichén Itzá expanded northward, the temple reflects the influence of central Mexican architectural styles.

### Did You Know?

• The 'tables' inside are stone altars used for offerings.

• Serpent-head columns at the entrance once supported a roof.

### Visitor Tip

Compare the serpent columns here with those at the Temple of the Warriors — they share the same architectural language.

---

## 128. The Temple of the Bearded Man

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A small temple in the North Group named for a relief carving of a figure with a beard, unusual in Maya art where beards are rarely depicted. The figure may represent a foreign dignitary or deity.

### Why It Matters

The bearded figure suggests cultural exchange or foreign influence, possibly from central Mexican or Gulf Coast traditions.

### Historical Context

Beards are uncommon in indigenous Mesoamerican art, leading some scholars to suggest the figure represents a non-Maya person or a deity associated with the wind god Kukulcan.

### Did You Know?

• The bearded figure is one of the few depictions of facial hair.

• Some theories suggest it depicts a Toltec or foreign ruler.

### Visitor Tip

Look carefully at the interior reliefs — the bearded figure is small but distinctive.

---

## 129. The Southeast Temple

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A temple in the southeastern area of Chichén Itzá, part of the broader ceremonial complex. It features a single chamber and a decorated facade, though much of the ornamentation has eroded.

### Why It Matters

Part of the extended ritual complex surrounding the main ceremonial center.

### Historical Context

The southeastern area includes several smaller temples and platforms that formed part of the city's expansion during its peak.

### Did You Know?

☞ The temple is one of the less-visited structures, offering a quiet

☞ Its isolated position suggests it served a specific neighborhood

#### Visitor Tip

Walk the quieter southeastern paths — you'll have this temple almost to yourself.

---

### 130. Cenote Xtoloc

*cenote · All periods (600–1200 CE)*

#### Description

The second-largest cenote at Chichén Itzá, located south of the main complex. Unlike the Sacred Cenote, which was used for offerings, Xtoloc was the primary source of drinking water for the city's inhabitants.

#### Why It Matters

The practical water source that sustained the daily life of Chichén Itzá's population.

#### Historical Context

While the Sacred Cenote was reserved for ritual purposes, Xtoloc served the everyday needs of thousands of residents. A *sacbe* (white road) connected it to the residential areas.

#### Did You Know?

☞ Xtoloc provided drinking water while the Sacred Cenote was used for offerings.

☞ A temple platform beside the cenote was used for rituals related to water.

#### Visitor Tip

Unlike the Sacred Cenote, you can see the water level here — it's much closer to the surface.

---

### 131. The Halach Uinik House

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

#### Description

Also known as the 'House of the Ruler,' this building near Las Monjas is believed to have been the residence of the halach uinik — the supreme ruler or governor of Chichén Itzá.

#### Why It Matters

Likely the administrative and residential center of Chichén Itzá's political leadership.

#### Historical Context

The halach uinik was the highest political authority in Maya society. This building's proximity to Las Monjas suggests the area served as a governmental complex.

#### Did You Know?

☞ 'Halach uinik' means 'real man' or 'true man' in Yucatec Maya.

☞ The building's layout suggests multiple rooms for administrative functions.

#### Visitor Tip

Imagine the ruler conducting affairs of state here — this was the political heart of the city.

---



## 132. Akab Dzib

*residential · Late Classic (600–900 CE)*

### Description

The 'Place of Obscure Writing' is a building south of the main complex with hieroglyphic inscriptions that remain undeciphered. It features a long gallery and a well-preserved lintel with Maya glyphs.

### Why It Matters

Contains some of the most extensive hieroglyphic inscriptions at Chichén Itzá, though their meaning remains a mystery.

### Historical Context

Built in the Late Classic period, Akab Dzib predates many of the central monuments. Its name was given by local Maya who could no longer read the glyphs.

### Did You Know?

☞ The lintel over the main door bears a Maya date inscription.

☞ The building's name 'Akab Dzib' means 'Obscure Writing' in Yucatec.

### Visitor Tip

Look up at the lintel above the doorway — the carved glyphs are some of the best-preserved at the site.

---

## 133. The Group of the Date

*other · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

### Description

A small complex named after a carved Maya date glyph found on one of its structures. The date corresponds to a specific day in the Maya Long Count calendar.

### Why It Matters

The carved date provides important chronological evidence for dating this part of the site.

### Historical Context

This small group shows that even minor structures at Chichén Itzá were marked with calendar dates, underscoring the Maya obsession with timekeeping.

### Did You Know?

☞ The carved date is one of the few Long Count dates found outside the main pyramid center.

☞ The glyph uses the bar-and-dot notation system for Maya numbers.

### Visitor Tip

Search for the carved date stone — it's small but a crucial piece of the site's chronology.

---

## 134. The Platform of the East

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

### Description

A ceremonial platform east of El Castillo, one of several platforms used for ritual displays and public ceremonies. Its carved panels depict warriors and feathered serpents.

### Why It Matters

Part of the ritual landscape surrounding El Castillo, used for public ceremonies and displays of power.

### Historical Context

Platforms like this were stages for rituals, dances, and possibly sacrificial ceremonies visible to large crowds gathered in the main plaza.

### Did You Know?

☞ The platform aligns with sunrise positions during the equinoxes.

☞ Its carvings show warriors with atlatis (spear-throwers) and shields.

#### Visitor Tip

Visit during sunrise to see how the platform aligns with the morning light.

---

## 135. The House of the Deer

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

### Description

Named for a mural depicting a deer hunt found inside. The building features rare surviving wall paintings, though most have faded significantly.

### Why It Matters

Preserves one of the few surviving examples of Maya mural painting at Chichén Itzá, depicting daily life rather than ritual scenes.

### Historical Context

Deer were important in Maya culture for both food and ritual. The hunt scene suggests this building may have been associated with hunting ceremonies or a noble hunting lodge.

### Did You Know?

☞ The deer mural was still partially visible in the 19th century before restoration.

☞ Deer were associated with the sun god and the hunt was a noble activity.

#### Visitor Tip

Bring binoculars or use your phone's zoom — faint traces of the deer mural survive high on the interior walls.

---

## 136. The House of the Phalluses

*temple · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

### Description

A building named for the phallic carvings that decorate its facade, associated with fertility rituals. Some carvings were removed by early archaeologists due to their explicit nature.

### Why It Matters

Represents the fertility cult at Chichén Itzá, where phallic symbolism was linked to agricultural abundance and regeneration.

### Historical Context

Fertility imagery was common in Mesoamerican ritual art, though few surviving examples are as explicit as this structure's decorations.

### Did You Know?

☞ Phallic imagery in Maya art symbolized fertility and the cycle of life.

☞ Some carvings were chiseled off by Victorian-era visitors who found them offensive.

#### Visitor Tip

Look carefully at the upper facade — a few of the original carvings survive if you know what to look for.

---

## 137. The Red House

*residential · Late Classic–Terminal Classic (800–900 CE)*

### Description

Also called Casa Colorada, this well-preserved building retains traces of its original red paint. Its interior walls are covered with hieroglyphic inscriptions recording a dedication date of 869 CE.

### Why It Matters

One of the few structures with a confirmed dedication date, anchoring the timeline of Chichén Itzá's late construction phase.

### Historical Context

The red paint was made from cinnabar or hematite, precious pigments that signaled the building's importance. The inscriptions name a ruler named K'ak'upakal.

### Did You Know?

- The dedication date 869 CE makes it one of the few precisely dated structures at Chichén Itzá.
- Red was the color of the east, sunrise, and resurrection in Maya cosmology.

### Visitor Tip

Look at the interior walls — traces of the original red pigment are still visible after 1,100 years.

---

## 138. The Steam Bath

*other · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

### Description

A ritual sweat lodge (temazcal) used for purification before ceremonies. It has a small chamber, a fire pit, and a water basin where steam was created by pouring water on heated stones.

### Why It Matters

Purification was essential before Maya rituals — the temazcal cleansed body and spirit for contact with the divine.

### Historical Context

Temazcales were used across Mesoamerica for both ritual and medicinal purposes. This is one of the best-preserved examples at a Maya site.

### Did You Know?

- The word 'temazcal' comes from Nahuatl: 'temaz' (steam) and 'cal' (house).
- Similar sweat lodges are still used in parts of Mexico today for purification.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the small doorway and the chimney vent — the engineering is remarkably similar to modern saunas.

---

## 139. Temple of the Inscriptions

*temple · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

### Description

A small temple once covered in Maya hieroglyphic inscriptions, now largely eroded. The remaining glyphs provide valuable records of dates and rituals from Chichén Itzá's history.

### Why It Matters

One of the few structures at Chichén Itzá with extensive hieroglyphic texts, offering clues to the city's dynastic history.

### Historical Context

The inscriptions mention dates and possibly rulers, but the Maya of Chichén Itzá used far fewer hieroglyphic texts than classic southern Maya cities.

### Did You Know?

- Many inscriptions have eroded beyond recovery due to the soft limestone.
- The temple's name comes from the long text band that once ran across the top of the structure.

### Visitor Tip

Try to spot the few remaining glyph blocks near the door — each is a word or date in the Maya writing system.

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## 140. Venus Platform

*platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

### Description

A small ornate platform near El Castillo dedicated to the planet Venus, the most important celestial body in Maya astronomy after the sun. Its carved panels show the Venus glyph and warrior imagery.

### Why It Matters

Commemorated the Maya Venus calendar and the planet's dual role as morning star (war god) and evening star.

### Historical Context

The Maya tracked Venus's 584-day cycle with extraordinary precision. Its appearances were times of both warfare and ritual, believed to influence earthly events.

### Did You Know?

- The Maya associated Venus with war and would launch raids timed to its appearances.
- The platform aligns with Venus sightlines from El Caracol.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the carved Venus symbols on the platform's sides — they resemble a shell or eye glyph.

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## 141. Initial Series Group

*other · Late Classic (600–900 CE)*

### Description

A complex of buildings named after a carved Maya Long Count date found here — one of the few dated inscriptions at Chichén Itzá. The date corresponds to 10.2.9.1.9 in the Maya calendar.

### Why It Matters

Provides crucial chronological evidence for dating the construction phases of Chichén Itzá.

### Historical Context

The Long Count date helped archaeologists establish that this part of the city was built earlier than the central zone, in the Late Classic period.

### Did You Know?

- The Long Count date is one of only a handful found at Chichén Itzá.
- This group predates El Castillo, showing the city grew over centuries.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the carved date glyph — it's a series of bar-and-dot numbers representing periods of time.

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## 142. The Ossuary

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A smaller stepped pyramid also called the High Priest's Grave. A shaft inside descends 12 meters into a natural cave where human bones and offerings were found — giving the structure its name.

### Why It Matters

A funerary monument marking a sacred cave, connecting the surface world with the underworld through its internal shaft tomb.

### Historical Context

The cave below the Ossuary was a ritual space long before the pyramid was built. The Maya believed caves were entrances to Xibalba, the underworld.

### Did You Know?

- The shaft tomb contained jade, copper, and ceramic offerings
- Serpent columns at the entrance mirror those of El Castillo on

### Visitor Tip

Notice the carved serpent heads at the base — a miniature echo of El Castillo's feathered serpents.

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## 143. The Marketplace

other · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)

### Description

A large colonnaded area believed to have been the commercial heart of Chichén Itzá, where goods from across Mesoamerica — jade, cacao, obsidian, feathers, and salt — were traded.

### Why It Matters

Evidence of Chichén Itzá's role as a major trade hub, connecting the Maya highlands, lowlands, and the Gulf Coast.

### Historical Context

The colonnaded market space could shelter hundreds of vendors and buyers. The nearby port of Isla Cerritos linked Chichén Itzá to maritime trade routes.

### Did You Know?

- Cacao beans were used as currency — a rabbit cost about 10
- Obsidian from central Mexican mines has been found here, pro

### Visitor Tip

Imagine the columns supporting a massive thatched roof — this was the ancient equivalent of a shopping mall.

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## 144. Tzompantli

platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A low, wide platform covered in carved human skulls. Its name means 'Wall of Skulls' in Nahuatl, reflecting its function as a rack for displaying the heads of sacrificial victims.

### Why It Matters

A monument to the power of death and sacrifice in Maya cosmology, symbolizing the cycle of life, death, and rebirth that sustained the universe.

### Historical Context

Similar skull racks are found across Mesoamerica, from the Aztecs of Tenochtitlan to the Maya of the Yucatán, representing a shared belief in the sacred power of sacrifice.

### Did You Know?

- Each carved skull is slightly different, possibly representing a different deity.
- The platform may have held real skulls on wooden posts mounted around the perimeter.

### Visitor Tip

Walk around all four sides — the carvings include serpents eating human hearts alongside the skull motifs.

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## 145. Temple of the Warriors

*temple · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)*

### Description

A grand stepped temple flanked by hundreds of carved columns depicting warriors. At its summit sits a Chac Mool — a reclining stone figure holding a bowl on its stomach, possibly for sacrificial offerings.

### Why It Matters

A monument to Chichén Itzá's military power, where warrior-society rituals and sacrifices were conducted under the gaze of the rain god Tlaloc.

### Historical Context

The temple is architecturally influenced by Toltec styles from central Mexico, suggesting cultural exchange or a shared ruling lineage between the two regions.

### Did You Know?

- The columns were originally painted in brilliant red, turquoise, and black.
- Over 200 warrior columns surround the temple, each carved with unique details.
- The Chac Mool at the top is one of the finest examples of this type of sculpture.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the murals on the inner walls of the upper temple — they show a great battle with warriors in canoes.

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## 146. Great Ball Court

*ball court · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)*

### Description

The largest and best-preserved Mesoamerican ball court, measuring 168 meters long. Its acoustics are extraordinary — a whisper at one end can be heard clearly at the other, 150 meters away.

### Why It Matters

The ball game (pok-ta-pok) was not merely sport but a sacred ritual reenacting cosmic cycles, often involving human sacrifice of the defeated team.

### Historical Context

The court features carved panels depicting the decapitation of a player, from which seven serpents spring — symbolizing fertility and rebirth through sacrifice.

### Did You Know?

- The acoustic properties are so precise they've been studied by scientists.
- The ball could weigh up to 4 kilograms and was struck with the hips.
- The hoop targets on the walls are only 30 cm wide — scoring was extremely difficult.

### Visitor Tip

Stand at one end and have a friend whisper from the other — the echo phenomenon is one of the site's most remarkable features.

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## 147. Temple of the Jaguars

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A small temple adjoining the Great Ball Court, adorned with carved jaguar motifs and murals depicting a great battle. Inside, a jaguar throne covered in jade and painted red was discovered.

### Why It Matters

Dedicated to the jaguar — the most powerful predator of the Maya world and a symbol of royal authority and military might.

### Historical Context

The temple's murals are among the few surviving examples of Maya battle scenes, likely depicting a historic military victory of Chichén Itzá over a rival city.

### Did You Know?

- The murals show warriors in elaborate feathered headdresses
- Jaguars were believed to be the spirit companions (wayob) of

### Visitor Tip

Look up at the carved columns — they show feathered serpents interwoven with jaguar imagery.

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## 148. El Caracol

observatory · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

The Maya observatory — its name means 'the snail,' referring to the spiral staircase inside. The building's windows are aligned with specific celestial events, including the northernmost and southernmost settings of Venus.

### Why It Matters

One of the most sophisticated astronomical observatories in the ancient world, demonstrating the Maya's mastery of celestial tracking and their reverence for the planet Venus.

### Historical Context

The Maya tracked the cycles of Venus with extraordinary precision. Their calculations (584-day Venus cycle) match modern measurements almost exactly — an achievement unmatched in the ancient world.

### Did You Know?

- The upper dome has sighting tubes aligned to track Venus at i
- The Maya Venus table in the Dresden Codex is accurate to wit
- The building was built in phases, each layer adjusted to corre

### Visitor Tip

Notice the slitted windows in the upper tower — they're not decorative but precise astronomical sighting instruments.

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## 149. El Castillo

temple · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

The iconic step pyramid of Kukulcan, standing 30 meters tall with nine terraced levels. Each side has a staircase of 91 steps; combined with the top platform, that's 365 — one for each day of the solar year.

### Why It Matters

A masterpiece of Maya astronomy and architecture, designed so that on the spring and autumn equinoxes, sunlight creates the illusion of a giant serpent slithering down the pyramid's northern staircase.

### Historical Context

Built atop an earlier pyramid, El Castillo encases a smaller temple within. Inside, archaeologists discovered a Chac Mool statue and a red jaguar throne inlaid with jade eyes.

### Did You Know?

☞ The pyramid is a giant calendar in stone: 52 panels per facade represent the 52-day calendar round.

☞ A second, older pyramid is hidden entirely inside this one.

☞ During the equinox, the shadow forms the body of Kukulcan, the serpent.

### Visitor Tip

Visit at sunrise or sunset for the most dramatic light on the pyramid's facades. The equinox serpent effect draws thousands — arrive early.

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## 150. Platform of the Eagles

platform · Terminal Classic (900–1100 CE)

### Description

A rectangular platform decorated with carved eagles and jaguars clutching human hearts. These animals were the avatars of the sun's journey through the sky and underworld.

### Why It Matters

Symbolized the military orders of eagle and jaguar warriors — elite soldiers who captured victims for sacrifice to feed the sun and ensure cosmic order.

### Historical Context

Eagle and jaguar warrior societies were pan-Mesoamerican military orders. Capturing enemies for sacrifice was a warrior's path to social advancement.

### Did You Know?

☞ Eagles were associated with the sun and daytime; jaguars with the night and underworld.

☞ The carvings show the animals holding hearts, representing the sun's journey.

### Visitor Tip

Compare the carving style here with the nearby Tzompantli — both use the same flattened, graphic approach to depicting the human form.

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## 151. Las Monjas

*residential · Late Classic–Terminal Classic (600–1000 CE)*

### Description

A grand complex originally called 'The Nunnery' by the Spanish, who thought its many small rooms resembled a convent. In reality, it was a palace for Maya royalty, covered in intricate stone carvings of masks, serpents, and deities.

### Why It Matters

One of the oldest and most richly decorated structures at Chichén Itzá, showcasing the transition between classic Maya and the later militaristic styles.

### Historical Context

Built in phases over centuries, Las Monjas shows distinct architectural layers — the earliest from the Late Classic period, with later additions reflecting the city's evolving political and religious identity.

### Did You Know?

- The facade is covered in hundreds of Chaac (rain god) masks and serpent carvings.
- An annex called 'La Iglesia' (The Church) was added later and features more intricate carvings.

### Visitor Tip

Examine the facade carvings closely — you'll find Chaac masks, serpents, and even armadillos carved into the stone.

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## 152. La Iglesia

*residential · Terminal Classic (900–1000 CE)*

### Description

A small, ornate building attached to Las Monjas, covered in elaborate stone carvings. Its facade is a gallery of symbolic animals: armadillos, snails, turtles, and the rain god Chaac — each representing different aspects of the Maya cosmos.

### Why It Matters

A compact but densely symbolic structure, representing the Maya worldview through its carved animal iconography and serving as an elite ceremonial space.

### Historical Context

La Iglesia was built as part of the Las Monjas complex expansion, reflecting the continued importance of this area as a seat of ritual and royal power through the city's history.

### Did You Know?

- The four animals on the facade may represent the four bacabs (earth deities) at the cardinal directions.
- Despite its name, there's no evidence it was ever a church.

### Visitor Tip

Look for the flying deity masks above the doorway — they represent the rain god Chaac in his role as a sky-bearer.

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## 153. Group of a Thousand Columns

column group · Terminal Classic–Early Postclassic (900–1200 CE)

### Description

A vast colonnade of hundreds of stone pillars, each carved with the image of a warrior. The columns once supported a massive thatched roof, creating a great covered market or assembly hall.

### Why It Matters

The largest columned hall in Mesoamerica, representing the economic and political power of Chichén Itzá at its peak as a regional capital.

### Historical Context

Similar colonnades are found at Tula, the Toltec capital, reinforcing the theory of close ties between the two cities. The space may have served as a market, council chamber, or ceremonial hall.

### Did You Know?

- There are actually around 200 columns, not 1,000 — the name is a misnomer.
- The columns are arranged in straight rows that create striking optical effects.
- Each column depicts a different warrior with unique headdress and attributes.

### Visitor Tip

Stand among the columns and note how the spacing creates precise sight lines — the Maya designed this for ceremonial processions.

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## 154. Sacred Cenote

cenote · Late Classic – Terminal Classic (600–900 CE)

### Description

A deep natural sinkhole filled with emerald water, revered by the Maya as a portal to the underworld (Xibalba). Archaeologists recovered jade, gold, ceramics, and human remains from its depths — offerings to the rain god Chaac.

### Why It Matters

The spiritual heart of Chichén Itzá's ritual life, where the Maya performed ceremonies to communicate with the gods of the underworld.

### Historical Context

Dredging expeditions in the early 20th century recovered over 50 skeletons and vast quantities of precious offerings, confirming the cenote's role as a site of pilgrimage and sacrifice.

### Did You Know?

- The water is 50 meters deep and partly fed by an underground river.
- Some offerings show marks of ritual heart extraction.

### Visitor Tip

Walk the narrow sacbé (white road) that connects the cenote to El Castillo — it's the same ceremonial path the Maya used.

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## 11. Visitor Tips & Practical Information

### Planning Your Visit

- **Best Time to Visit:** Arrive early (8:00 AM) or late afternoon to avoid crowds and heat. March brings the famous equinox serpent shadow on El Castillo.
- **Duration:** Allow 3–4 hours to explore the main monuments. With NESS Wonders, plan extra time to scan and listen to each landmark's story.
- **What to Bring:** Sunscreen, a hat, comfortable walking shoes, and plenty of water. There is little shade on site. Headphones enhance the audio narration experience.
- **Phone Battery:** AR features use your camera continuously, which drains battery fast. Bring a portable charger.
- **Connectivity:** The app works with an internet connection for AI scanning and audio generation. Download this guide for offline reference.
- **Stay Hydrated:** The Yucatán sun is intense. Drink water frequently, especially when walking between distant monuments.
- **Respect the Site:** Do not climb on restricted structures, touch carvings, or remove anything. Chichén Itzá is a sacred site and a protected World Heritage area.
- **Photography:** Photography is allowed throughout the site. The AR scanner works best in good lighting conditions.

*Enjoy your journey through the ancient city of Chichén Itzá with NESS Wonders.*